

YUKA

User Research

User Research · Competitive Check · Goal Setting · Personas · PO Problem

What YUKA Does

A mobile app that allows people to quickly check if a food or cosmetic product is healthy and safe for them by letting them scan the product and providing a score based on multiple factors such as nutritional value, presence of additives, hazardous chemicals, and more.

Section 01 — Research Objective & Methodology

Research Objective

To understand how YUKA is used by general health conscious/wellness category - how is their experience with scanning, how scores shape their decisions, and identify the frictions in finding products on YUKA, trusting the scores or getting the alternative recommended products, and being receptive of any other concerns that the users bring to light

Type	Method	Nos.	Context
Primary	User Interviews	5	General Wellness/Health conscious individuals who use YUKA for scanning food/cosmetic products (friends,colleagues,communities) https://notebooklm.google.com/notebook/cf10b160-4317-4092-a333-c4b41154ef52
	User Survey	54	Regular YUKA users sourced online https://forms.gle/UPusYPviGozGa3XN9
Secondary	Platform Analysis	150+	Synthesized sentiment from Reddit, Trust Pilot, App Store reviews, and community thread

Section 02 — Insights from Users (The Evidence)

Insight 1 : Scoring seems misleading due to lack of context

The QUAL (VOICE OF THE USER)	THE QUANT(SCALE OF PROBLEM)
The Qual (Voice of the User) <i>"I was surprised by 'excellent','good' scores I got for kids Kellog's cereals.I personally researched through a book to confirm my concern that its</i>	The Quant (Scale of Problem) Users are feeling mislead as scoring does not take into account their specific needs or concerns,portion size and is primarily based on Nutriscores.More than 80% of respondents have selected they personally didn't choose

The QUAL (VOICE OF THE USER)	THE QUANT(SCALE OF PROBLEM)
<i>nutritionally thin and ultra processed, not something to let my child have as daily breakfast. I don't know if those are taken into account while ranking</i> <i>Sometimes healthy products are given poor scores, when scores are not as expected, I check the detailed ingredients, but only for additives and still buy the products if it doesn't have any chemical/toxins. I am fine with slightly higher calories or fats"</i> - Gina, 38 (Interviewee #2)	to buy a product rated by YUKA as good/excellent as the product didn't suit their health needs or contained ingredients they didn't want and 33.9% of those felt they couldn't explain it, but it didn't feel right. Though YUKA never intended to score ultra processed foods as excellent, that's how people perceive it and are actively mislead ,and they either do their own research and ignore the scores or lose confidence in the app, stop using it.

Insight 2 : Inconsistent scoring leads to disappointment

The QUAL (VOICE OF THE USER)	OBSERVED BEHAVIOR
The Qual (Voice of the User) <i>"When I scanned 'Dunnes' wholemeal baps, they got a poor score and I got 'Tesco' baps as alternate recommended. I know both of them are store-owned and could even be produced at the same place with similar ingredients. But sometimes I don't get why are scores different, not sure if its only due to additives or why is fibre or other macros different, how accurate are those values or what it means ".</i> - Eoin, 42 (Interviewee #3)	OBSERVED BEHAVIOR Users are sometimes confused as to why scores differ for similar products or if its a glitch and sometimes why are perfectly good foods rated bad .They are confused and have to manually go through ingredients details and still they are not able to understand the rationale . Quick compare just gives them scores but doesn't give any text/summary to show why they differ

Insight 3 : Recommended products not available in store

<i>"I wanted to get pitted olives with basil and scores for Tesco's was poor . The alternates suggested was from Sainsbury's and those</i>	Users are not able to find the suggested alternative products in stores and sometimes they are available only online
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are not available in the store .I ended up scanning other brands in the same aisle and never got what I wanted ”

-Vish,32

or in other stores. Though ‘availability’ is a key factor for recommendations, there is no information to indicate ‘availability in store’ to user and sometimes recommended alternates are not available

Section 03 — Hypothesis Check (where we are now)

Validated	Invalidated	Discovered New.
1. Lack of personalisation / misleading scores Confirmed. Scoring/Recommendations does not consider unique user’s context and users feel they are mislead. They don’t understand why some good products are scored poor and vice versa and are doing their own research elsewhere 2. ‘Inconsistent scores’ create confusion and reduce confidence Confirmed Similar products sometime are scored differently for minute variations .That is not evident for the end user, leading to questions on scores’ reliability and they have to spend more effort to understand the labels, factors causing the differences No notification to user on change of scores for products they have scanned before . Lack of reasoning behind the change annoys users and they feel frustrated when there is no consistency with ratings of same product 3. Difficulty in getting recommended products : Confirmed Users struggle to find the recommended alternatives in the shops they are in. The alternatives suggested may be available in others stores or available only online and there is no indication about availability	All users rely completely on the score for buying decisions False. Some ignore the score and continue to buy the product if they have been using it regularly or if they know it was scored poorly for reasons they don’t care about Lack of weekly insights or rewards makes it uninteresting for users to re-engage with app : False This never came up as issue as most of them try one or two different products regularly and 83.9% of survey respondents have confirmed they use the app a few times weekly or monthly ,even without any weekly emails or rewards to motivate them	Expectations for Nuanced details : Users expect the app to go beyond general advice on diet or health . There is a need to provide nuanced details such as presence of micro plastics, ultra processing levels, differentiating healthy fats, why are similar products scoring very different etc Learning tool , but only for ‘additives’ : People are using YUKA as learning tool to know more about additives and just read ‘additives section’ as they know some foods are high in fat or sugar etc and YUKA doesn’t consider context for macros, nutrients

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Competitive Check

YUKA competes in the product safety and health scoring space. Below is a summary of what have competitors done about the same problems.

VALIDATED PROBLEM	COMPETITOR	WHAT THEY HAVE DONE	WHAT IT TELLS YOU
Users are feeling mislead as scoring does not take into account their specific needs or concerns, portion size and they are annoyed when some ‘healthy’ foods are scored poor and vice versa	Nutra safe	*No scanner apps give full picture and scores give only a high level overview ,just as a quick starting point. Portion size, diet, how is product processed/cooked, frequency of consumption, and individual needs such as their health goal, food preferences all matter. And apps are struggling to strike a balance between all these factors ‘Nutra safe’ has tried to solve this partially by tracking not just nutrients but adding some context by considering portion size, tracking calories,allergens,vitamins etc	No direct food scanning competitor has solved contextual scoring issue well. This seems to be a problem by design as systems try to simplify the food scoring based on specific scientific factors while choosing to disregard others. People seem to want factor flexibility ie the ability to score food based on factors they choose
Users are confused when similar products are scored differently . It could be due to minute variations, which are not evident for the end user, leading to questions on scores’ reliability and they have to spend more effort to understand the labels, factors causing the differences. Also sometimes scores have changed for same products ,people do not have any idea and this contributes to more frustration, lack of trust on the app	Ivy	Ivy improves on transparency by offering deeper ingredient level insights, highlighting factors like processing,contaminants.by providing more detailed breakdown it can make it somewhat easier for users to understand why similar products may score differently, especially when differences are not immediately visible.	Though Ivy considers more factors, it still relies on overall rating and the increased number of factors can also make scoring harder to interpret consistently. (Same as first issue)

Challenges in getting the recommended alternatives from shops they are in. The alternatives suggested may be available in others stores or available only online and there is no indication about availability		This is not completely resolved by competitors as there are structural difficulties in integrating with the stores to verify product availability	There seems to be a need for location based recommendations ie ability to recommend products that are available in stores where shoppers are or their location
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YUKA - Goal Setting

Clustering Problems and Finding Direction

Validated Problem	Short Label	Business Metric
Scoring feels misleading. Users feel the scoring is not accurate in some cases and does not consider their individual health preferences such as ultra processing levels, micro plastics, allergens , portion size etc . This results in scores that users find unacceptable ie some healthy products can be scored low and vice versa. Because of this they limit the app to only scan for additive, than a tool that gives them confidence in making overall healthy choice ✓ Focus cluster	Engagement	Users engage less with app when they start finding the core scores questionable. Users research elsewhere to get the same information in relation to their needs or some users ignore the scores and do whatever feels right for them .Structural difficulties in solving this as food scoring is dependent on factors at many layers such as portion size, individual needs etc
'Inconsistent scores' create confusion and reduce confidence Similar products sometime are scored differently for minute variations .The app doesn't make the rationale for the difference in scoring obvious and users have to spend more time to zero in on the exact factors contributing to the difference	Monetization	Users question the value of upgrading given the core scoring feature is unreliable
Lack of communication Another challenge due to inconsistent scoring is when scores change for a product they have previously scanned, they don't have the clear explanation and they happened to see it by chance. This lack of communication is reducing users trust	Retention	Users who feel disappointed that the products they got had good scores at first scan and they don't have the idea when or why had it gone down. As they are not informed of change, they happen to notice it by chance .The scores feel like scam , even though there were valid reasons that caused the rating to go down. Such users may stop using the app

Goal Statement

Improve retention for health-conscious, general wellness users.

Section 04 — User Personas

Susan Paul Healthy eating and clean personal care products – focused .Mother · Occupational Therapist · Regular user, 6 months	
Goals and Motivations - Interested in scanning food products to ensure if they are free of additives, healthy, not highly processed - Have YUKA provide accurate scores that she can rely on for her, family’s healthy eating habits - Use YUKA to avoid cosmetics, kids personal care products such as soaps, suncreams that includes chemicals or toxins	- Opens YUKA to scan products few times a week when they do their shopping in stores - Looks for details on products scanned at past (history) to understand ingredients (as she doesn’t have time to go through them while at stores) - Doesn’t maintain any list of favourites, uses mainly to get quick scores - Sometimes ignores YUKA score and buys the product as she knows that’s healthy enough for her needs
Frustrations "I don’t understand why some healthy products are scored so low just because it has bit of salt." "I cant find how much ultra processing has gone into making of	Context Uses YUKA for identifying foods that are healthy for her and family, would like to view ultra processing levels but not too concerned if product is slightly high on calories or healthy fats

it. I would be interested in microplastics in food .I don't know if ranking takes all of that into account" • Sometimes scores don't look right and additional checking of all ingredients is required	• Uses YUKA when shopping in store or at home to look up ingredients • When scores are not as expected, manually goes through ingredients lists and buys the products if its meeting her needs and limits YUKA just for checking additives
"Sometimes the scores are off ,so I manually check the ingredients details, but only for additives .I know I am fine with slightly high calories or fats " Gina, 38 (Interviewee #2) ✓ Relevance Check Does this person's regular experience with the product put him directly in contact with the problems in the Engagement cluster? Yes. Susan uses YUKA once or twice each week to check scores for products while shopping – the main concerns she cares about are nutrients, additives, ultra processing levels, micro plastics presence. Only first two factors are covered by YUKA in detailed ingredients list. Also when some products she considers 'healthy' are scored poorly, she just checks for 'additives' on the app and does not rely on the whole score. She ignores the score and buys the product based on her knowledge, needs. So she is happy enough to just limit YUKA for additives checking in free version and doesn't intend to upgrade as she feels ranking may not be robust enough for all other factors.	

Conor Behal Organic foods and fitness,high protein diet – focused IT Manager · Regular user, 1 year

Goals and Motivations ● Interested in discovering good quality food products, protein rich foods , organic and knowing source of manufacturing ● Time crunched for researching on own, so relies on app for quick, accurate scores ● Needs to compare different brands before buying a product	● Uses YUKA for scanning products while at work, while at shops ● Trusts the scores from app and avoids buying products scoring poor/bad ● Doesn't go through detailed ingredients list as much and mainly uses for quick scan, alternative recommendations
Frustrations ● "Sometimes recommendation products are UK centric and are not available here in Ireland. " ● "I am confused when similar products are getting different scores ,the ones I know could mostly be sourced from same place. The quick compare doesn't show why scores are different .Sometimes I check ingredients details and don't get those ratings, not very clear as to why fibre is more on bread than on oats. I don't know how are those calculated and if I can trust them" ● The gap between 'poor' and 'good' is so thin (49-poor and good- 51) ,and I am not sure ,sometimes 'poor' with 49 seem good to me ● It would be useful if I can trace 'organic' levels of foods if they were originally sourced in Ireland as in this market, if something is packaged in	Context ● Regular user who relies on app primarily for healthy buying ● Uses YUKA when shopping food products in store or at work ● Confused when similar products score differently and doesn't feel right overall, would prefer rationale to be highlighted ● As recommended alternatives are not available in store, avoids buying poor products but finds it time consuming to check for them later

Ireland, technically they label it as 'made in Ireland' though it is not produced here. I don't know if organic traceability to that level is considered when scoring products for 'organic' factor.	
<i>"When I scanned 'Dunnes' wholemeal baps, they got a poor score and I got 'Tesco' baps as alternate recommended. I know both of them are store-owned and could even be produced at the same place with similar ingredients. But sometimes I don't get why are scores different "</i> Eoin, 42 (Interviewee #2) ✓ Relevance Check Does this person's regular experience with the product put him directly in contact with the problems in the Engagement cluster? Yes. Conor uses YUKA regularly to check scores for products while shopping and at work – the main concerns are he cannot spot the reason for different scores when products are made with similar ingredients and he wants to quickly understand why one had scored better over other , if that factor is agreeable for him . Just looking at scores in compare screen doesn't make sense to him. If he reads through the ingredients (which he seldom does due to lack of time) , he is still not sure if macros calculated are accurate or how they come up with those numbers. Another concern is that recommended products are from UK and he cannot get them in Ireland.He still uses the app for buying decisions but is sometime skeptical with the scoring algorithm, causing decrease in trust	

Section 05 — P0

VALIDATED PROBLEM	P	I	F	TOTAL	REASONING
Scoring feels misleading as they lack context Scores do not consider individual needs and appear misleading ie sometimes products they know are 'healthy' for them seem to score poorly and some products that are not good for	3	3	5	11	Affects a meaningful portion of the users and it gradually reduces trust in the app. This leads to lack of conversion and limits the usage of the app to just an additive scanner than an app that helps them buy healthy products overall. Happens regularly , a few times a month

their needs, tend to get better scores and users feel mislead					
'Inconsistent scores' create confusion and reduce confidence Similar products sometime are scored differently for minute variations .The app doesn't make the rationale for the difference in scoring obvious and users have to spend more time to zero in on the exact factors contributing to the difference	3	3	3	9	A good few users have shared their frustrations when similar products score differently and not knowing why one is better over the other as the differences are minor or not very obvious
Inconsistent scores and Communication Gap When scores change poorly for a product they have previously scanned and got 'good'/'excellent' rating, users are confused as they don't have the clear explanation and they lose trust in app	1	5	1	7	Some users have come across downgrading of scores to products that were rated well the first time they scanned. Though they have not noticed it regularly, when it happens once they don't trust the app anymore
Recommendations not available Products recommended are sometimes not available in stores and users need alternative recommendations specific to their location	1	3	3	7	This seems to affect UK and Ireland specific shoppers. They have challenges in getting the recommended alternatives in the physical stores or nearby shops.

P0 Problem Statement :

Health conscious/General wellness focused users are finding the scores are misleading as some products that they know that are 'healthy' for them are poorly scored and vice versa (**example:** ' toasted sunflower seeds snack ', scoring '**poor**' as its high on fats,calories but those are good fats for some,some don't mind more calories, salt .'Kellogg's cereals' scored '**excellent**' because its low on calories and doesn't have additives , but some users are concerned that they are ultra-processed food and nutritionally thin,so it shouldn't be scoring 'excellent') . This lack of contextual scoring leads to confusion and reduces trust in the app. They don't go for conversion as they are not happy with 'basic' scoring and use the app only for 'additives' checking, this affects revenue as it reduces conversion. If this is not addressed, it could gradually reduce engagement and affect retention in future.